

The Battle of Hydaspes, 326BC

The last major battle that Alexander fought was at the River Hydaspes against a much different force from that of the Persians. This battle is perhaps the best example of Alexander's brilliance due to the circumstances under which it was fought.

Alexander, with 7000 cavalry, 40 000 infantry and 5000 Indian allies, met Porus, the Parvataka king, with an army of 30 000 to 50 000 good infantry, 85 to 200 elephants and 400 to 1000 chariots. The River Hydaspes was swollen and deep. Alexander realised he could not force a crossing of the river with Porus' army protecting the other side. He decided to trick Porus. He announced that his intention was to wait until the river went down and so had his men collect supplies for a long stay, all the time looking for a place to cross.

At night Alexander kept Porus and his army awake by regularly pretending to get the Macedonians ready to cross the river. At first these movements were met by the Indian officers calling out their troops and elephants but eventually they relaxed and did not respond. Alexander eventually found an easier crossing place and split his army into three groups. Craterus commanded one group—Indian allies and a force of Macedonians—with orders to attack across the river if it was left unguarded. Craterus was

also given some artillery to fire across the river as Alexander attacked. This would help to create confusion among the Indians. Meleager, with some pezetairoi and Greek mercenaries, went up river and was told to cross once the main Indian forces' attention was diverted.

Meanwhile, Alexander took the cavalry, the hypaspists and some other troops to cross the river at an island 27 kilometres downstream. He crossed at dawn but was spotted. Porus sent a force under the command of his son, which arrived too late to stop Alexander from crossing. Alexander promptly defeated the Indian force. Porus then advanced with his best troops against Alexander. With his elephants in front of him and the cavalry and chariots on the wings he attacked. Alexander kept his infantry back and put most of his cavalry on his right wing with Coenus. Alexander then attacked the Indian left flank. Porus sent his remaining cavalry to help the troops on his left wing but they soon found themselves surrounded.

The Indian cavalry now fell back onto the elephants and infantry to regroup, but only caused chaos as the Macedonian infantry attacked. Eventually successive Macedonian charges compressed the Indian army into a confused mass. The elephants, harassed by light troops

with axes and with many of their drivers dead, turned on their own men, trampling many. The exhausted elephants finally retreated, leaving the rest of the Indian army surrounded by the Macedonians.

Indian losses were said to be 12 000 to 23 000 killed, all of the chariots destroyed, and all the elephants killed or captured. Macedonian losses were 230 to 280 cavalry and between 80 and 700 infantry. The Macedonians had now secured what would be the easternmost boundary of Alexander's empire. Once again, with a force of some 18 500 troops, Alexander had defeated a much larger force (some 34 000 with 200 elephants and 300 chariots) by his tactical brilliance and the discipline of his forces.

- Copy the diagram below into your book. Divide the battle into six stages and draw them. Write a paragraph for each describing what is happening in each stage.
- What problems did Alexander have to face at this battle? How did he solve them?
- Imagine that you are one of the Indian soldiers in Porus' army. Describe the events of this battle.
- Imagine that you are a journalist covering the battle for an afternoon paper. Write two headlines that could be used on a front page account of this battle.

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